squares at different points, a feature created to relieve the congestion in the narrow pathways. These squares were scattered all across the city, providing some breathing space amidst cramped and narrow lanes. The presence of a stone bench in the south-west corner of one of these squares, known as Square S, around or before the beginning of the Mauryan occupation also suggests that these were meant to be used by the populace. From such street furniture it is possible to imagine ancient Taxilans shooting the breeze in their city squares.

Except that the breeze they shot may have been rather smelly. The squares seem also to have served as public areas where large garbage bins, built of stone rubble, were located. One of these, on the east side of Square S, known by the bones and broken pottery that were excavated out of it, leaves little doubt that it was used by houses in its neighbourhood for refuse disposal.[28] These public garbage bins will have required a class of sweepers and refuse collectors, well-to-do citizens in the ancient world not being famous for personally disposing off their own household garbage, and certainly never in the subcontinent's caste-ordered social system. There would also have had to be a system in place to clean out those bins and prevent garbage overflows on to streets and squares.

Notwithstanding such a system, solid refuse was sometimes dumped into soak-wells meant for liquid refuse. This seems to have been the case with a soak-well situated in a square at the intersection of Lane 3 and Lane 4 in the eastern part of the city.[29] It was filled with a large quantity of pottery vessels, as many as 164 of them, choking the whole shaft of the well.[30] The dumped vessels may have contained household kitchen waste, or else they had outlived their utility and were just chucked. That they were thrown in such large numbers into a well meant for liquid waste suggests that the subcontinent's famed contemporary incompetence in the sphere of public hygiene and civic-mindedness goes quite a long way back. Of course, it is possible that when distant dignitaries and their emissaries came visiting, the